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The World War I Thread

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Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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The World War I Thread

#1

07-10-2017, 05:44 PM

Since World War I is both a popular time period to talk about and looking to be one of the great crossover eras, I thought I'd make this thread to discuss it.

Goodbye to All That: Vampire. Set in the European and Ottoman Theatres. Focuses on the destruction of the old regimes, the brutality of vampire societies in the trenches, and rise of the Carthians to the height of their power. From Ancient Bloodlines & Ancient Mysteries.
Ruins of Empire: Mummy. Set in the North African and Middle Eastern Theatres. Focuses on the fracturing and decay of the English, French, and Ottoman Empires over the course of the Great War. From Dark Eras.
The Master's Tools: Demon. Set on the Eastern Front and Russian Revolution. More of the focus is on the Revolution itself, but that is, of course, triggered by and changes the flow of the War. From Dark Eras Companion.
The Western Front: Werewolf and Geist. Set on the Western Front (thanks, tips). Don't know much yet, but here's the quote from the Dark Eras 2 Kickstarter:

> *The Great War displayed humanity's potential to commit to wholesale, ceaseless slaughter of their own species. In such an era, the Scar tears asunder, and the Beshilu rejoice in the mire of the Western Front. Meanwhile, soldiers who, by every right known to mortals should be dead, stand back up to rejoin the battle — or fight back against the Reapers stalking battlefields throughout Europe. Now, both werewolves and Sin-Eaters will struggle to coexist, do their duty, and avoid getting caught up in one of history's deadliest wars.*

So has anyone set a Chronicle in the Great War before? What happened? What other parts of World War 1 would you like to explore? What other gamelines would you like to include?

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | **Patreon**| **He/His** | **Currently Writing**: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

Tags: None

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atamajakki
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 5487

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07-10-2017, 06:39 PM #2

If you want a fantastic crossover setting, Istanbul was divided up and occupied after WW1 in a very similar manner to Berlin after WW2; if you want mortal espionage from Ottoman, Turkish revolutionary, British, French, and Italian agents (to say nothing of the supernatural factions at play), look no further.

Remi. she/her. game designer.

2

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Cinder
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1408

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07-10-2017, 06:53 PM #3

Right off the bat, I'd say it would be cool to play in Sarajevo within the political environment that lead to the Archduke assassination. Or even just the powder keg that was Europe was before the war.

Also, in Italy you have poets that convince the population to agree going to war with over the top gestures and general patriotic exaltation. A pretty wild moment that will lead to all that idealism to crush against the realities of war. The whole country was not prepared, technologically and culturally, to fight any kind of war against the other big powers of Europe: WW1 put Italy through a crucible that, on one hand, unified the population but, on the other, lead to...certain bad things a few years later.

I also always have been fascinated by the impact WW1 style of warfare had on the minds of the soldiers, leading to the sort of PTSD that's pretty much a creation of the 20th Century. It, and its early treatments, are an interesting, if dark and grim, topic. Good material for Beast and Changeling, among others.

Might have more tomorrow, since I probably should go to bed right now

Last edited by Cinder; 07-10-2017, 06:55 PM.

Cinder's Comprehensive Collection of Creations - Homebrew Hub

I write about Beast: The Primordial a lot

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wyrdhamster
Banned

Join Date: Dec 2013
Posts: 11313

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07-11-2017, 02:48 AM #4

I just want to question/point out - Scars are not Werewolf term (maybe they are from Geist?), but Wounds are corrupted places of Shadow Realm. Pointing what tsar done in Russia also sounds as 'not one the subject' of the Western Front for this Dark Era.

EDIT: Re-reading phrase 'Scar tears asunder' I understand it's mean totally different things and have nothing to overthrown Tzar in Russia or Wounds in Hisil. Still, I would point out that this mass killing must spread Maeljinn corruption on to Shadow Realm in those trenches. Hell, whole Great War is surely feeding Thurifuge, Architect of Violence and
Asmodai, Queen of Wrath.

Last edited by wyrdhamster; 07-11-2017, 03:05 AM.

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glamourweaver
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 7541

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07-11-2017, 03:18 AM #5

WWI has some nice nuance as a setting as you can present the war itself as the ultimate evil as the characters deal with the fallout without one side being in the right and the otherside wholly evil. "Which side were you on?" "The one in the mud" - and all that.

The more overdone WW2 narratives tend to quickly become more Manichean in nature. The war itself is only evil in that it the manifestation of Axis aggression. Those who oppose fighting in the war are capitulating to fascism, rather than refusing to participate in a senseless clash of Empires using their citizens as cannonfodder (ala WWI). "Sometimes peace is another word for surrender" - and all that. You couldn't have the story of the Christmas Peace in a WW2 setting (not unless it ends with German soldiers defecting to the Allied side). The Allied side is incontrovertibly in the right comparatively - the only way to end the war is the unconditional surrender of the Axis so their regimes can be utterly dismantled.

That of course may be why WW2 narratives are overdone to the degree they are - because they're morally simpler stories than WWI narratives are. It's a lot easier to talk about how grandpa fought to defeat fascism, than how great grandpa bravely fought in a war over dominance of imperial territories to make a small handfull of people on either side rich at the equal expense of the brutalized soldiers on both sides of No Man's Land.

Last edited by glamourweaver; 07-11-2017, 04:08 AM.

Check out my expansion to the Realm of Brass and Shadow

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Michael
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 3559

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07-11-2017, 07:55 AM #6

I've found it interesting to role-play the people who were heavily invested in the war; I think there's a tendency to simply ignore soldiers agency in the war.

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Mad_Maudlin
Member

Join Date: Jun 2017
Posts: 229

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07-11-2017, 04:22 PM #7

I've long had a morbid fascination with Ireland during WW1, and the Easter Rising in particular. Like the Russian Revolution, it's a Demon-friendly environment, but I think it could also be a fascinating setting for a Geist campaign. Mostly thanks to this quote from Padraig Pearse:

"They think that they have pacified Ireland. They think that they have purchased half of us and intimidated the other half. They think that they have foreseen everything, think that they have provided against everything; but the fools, the fools, the fools! - they have left us our Fenian dead, and while Ireland holds these graves, Ireland unfree shall never be at peace."

3

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Flyboy254
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 703

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07-11-2017, 08:16 PM #8

> *Originally posted by* ***glamourweaver***
>
> *That of course may be why WW2 narratives are overdone to the degree they are - because they're morally simpler stories than WWI narratives are. It's a lot easier to talk about how grandpa fought to defeat fascism, than how great grandpa bravely fought in a war over dominance of imperial territories to make a small handfull of people on either side rich at the equal expense of the brutalized soldiers on both sides of No Man's Land.*

I don't know, the show Foyle's War did a good job of looking at WWII, especially in the early days, certainly had some moral ambiguity to it from the civilian point

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of view.

As for WWI, there's always more than the front lines or the regions everyone thinks about as important to the war. There was military action in Central Africa, high-seas terror thanks to the u-boats, new technologies springing up to make the killing more efficient/win the war faster, and of course the political wheeling and dealing necessary to carry on the war effort for even another week.

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glamourweaver
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 7541

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07-11-2017, 10:51 PM #9

> *Originally posted by **Flyboy254***
>
> *I don't know, the show Foyle's War did a good job of looking at WWII, especially in the early days, certainly had some moral ambiguity to it from the civilian point of view.*

From a "from the limited perspective of the people on the ground at the time" maybe. But the historic context of the narrative and the full nature of the Third Reich's campaign for Europe and world as already playing out in the territory they controlled is pretty inescapable.

Admittedly my perspective on '39 may be being colored from my position as an ethnically-Polish Jew.

And similarly any ambiguity that might stem from an anti-Western Imperialism view of the "co-prosperity sphere" is given lie by Japan's preceding 29 years in Korea.

Last edited by glamourweaver; 07-11-2017, 10:58 PM.

Check out my expansion to the Realm of Brass and Shadow

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Michael
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 3559

07-12-2017, 03:47 AM #10

> *Originally posted by **glamourweaver***
> *From a "from the limited perspective of the people on the ground at the time" maybe. But the historic context of the narrative and the full nature of the Third Reich's campaign for Europe and world as already playing out in the territory they controlled is pretty inescapable.*

I'd say that's the heart of moral ambiguity. The contrast between the grand morality of a conflict and the individuals lived experience.

That said, that's another reason for WW1 being a bit easier, the moral ambiguity

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between soliders fighting on opposite sides of a war is a lot more acceptable than.the moral ambiguity of administrating a ghetto.

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glamourweaver
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 7541

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07-12-2017, 05:10 AM #11

*Originally posted by **Michael***

I'd say that's the heart of moral ambiguity. The contrast between the grand morality of a conflict and the individuals lived experience.

That said, that's another reason for WW1 being a bit easier, the moral ambiguity between soliders fighting on opposite sides of a war is a lot more acceptable than.the moral ambiguity of administrating a ghetto.

I don't believe the latter is moral ambiguity. The fact that human beings are very good at rationalizing and convincing themselves they're not evil, no matter what they're doing, does not actually make the actively carrying out genocide less objectively evil. This does admittedly apply in WW1 with regard to the Ottomans/Turks as well.

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Michael
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 3559

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07-12-2017, 09:40 AM #12

*Originally posted by **glamourweaver***
I don't believe the latter is moral ambiguity. The fact that human beings are very good at rationalizing and convincing themselves they're not evil, no matter what they're doing, does not actually make the actively carrying out genocide less objectively evil.

Sorry I wasn't clearer, I was referring specifically to the Jewish councils set up to run the ghettos, not the Nazis.

1

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glamourweaver
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 7541

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07-12-2017, 04:54 PM #13

Ah, yes, I see your point then. Yes you can certainly find cases of moral conflict over how to survive the worst of circumstances.

Check out my expansion to the Realm of Brass and Shadow

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Second Chances
Member

Join Date: Dec 2014
Posts: 4201

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07-17-2017, 10:44 PM #14

So here are my current thoughts for expansion ideas of the Western Front era, in no particular order:

In the Great War, the landscape becomes a wasteland that even the Prometheans have difficulty understanding. A new lineage rises from the gases first unleashed in Ypres, and both the living and the Created must wander far from home.

Men, boys really, and snatched up by the dozens each day during World War 1. Most of it is the work of propaganda, conscription, and the recruiting machine, but the Gentry are at work across the Western Front too. Those Changelings who do manage to make their way back from Arcadia are left wondering if this War is really better than what they left behind as they struggle to create Freeholds in the Trenches and occupied cities.

Monsters lurk under your bed, at least until the real monsters march into your city. Innocents during the Great War must contend with both no matter which side of the war they are on. France, Britain, Belgium, or Germany... none of them are safe.

Hunters must march to war while still keeping up the Vigil. Monster hunting is dangerous prospect as it is, but in no-man's land, it's even worse.

In the shadows and shell craters, darkness breeds and spread. The Infected reach new heights during the war, their occult pathogen hidden within by the other disease ravenging the trenches.

Vampire is another possibility, especially because I love both of the bloodlines in Ancient Bloodlines, but it is probably an outside possibility since we already know about Vampires during the Great War.

Chris H/EndDaysEngine | **Patreon**| **He/His** | **Currently Writing**: *[Redacted], [Redacted]*

CofD booklists: Beast I Changeling | Demon | Deviant | Geist I Hunter I Mage | Mummy | Promethean | Vampire | Werewolf

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Runcible
Member

Join Date: Apr 2015
Posts: 164

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07-17-2017, 11:04 PM #15

I think Beast could make well for an expansion to Western Front. What with battlefields and trenches as a lair, gases and shrapnel as environmental conditions, and Beasts themselves being able to personify the horrors of war and become PTSD incarnate for the soldiers present.

👍 1

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